5 Root Cause Analysis Mistakes

That keep your incidents coming back

Swipe to learn →

#1

Stopping at "Human Error"

❌ THE MISTAKE

"Root cause: Worker failed to follow procedure"

✓ INSTEAD ASK

WHY was it possible for them to fail? Was the procedure practical? Was there pressure to shortcut?

#2

Weak Corrective Actions

❌ THE MISTAKE

"Retrain all workers" or "Add more warning signs"

✓ INSTEAD

Use the Hierarchy of Controls. Start with elimination and engineering — not just admin controls that rely on human behavior.

#3

Confirmation Bias

❌ THE MISTAKE

Forming conclusions early, then gathering evidence that confirms your theory

✓ INSTEAD

Deliberately seek disconfirming evidence. Ask: "What would prove my theory wrong?"

#4

Not Reaching Organization

❌ THE MISTAKE

Stopping at equipment failure or procedural gaps without asking WHY

✓ INSTEAD ASK

"What management decision or system allowed this condition to exist?" That's where root causes live.

#5

Investigating in Isolation

❌ THE MISTAKE

Treating each incident as unique. Filing and forgetting.

✓ INSTEAD

Look for patterns across incidents. The same organizational factors often appear again and again.

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